

Over two months, millions of viewers watched from around the world as 25 world champions were crowned in Paris.

The journey from Riyadh to Paris

Less than two months earlier, however, there was no certainty that the tournament would happen at all.

Organised by the Esports Foundation, the event was originally scheduled to take place in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, which had hosted the previous two editions. But the ongoing conflict in West Asia made staging a tournament of this scale in the region a bridge too far.

"It was complex. I think we had about 50 days, somewhat less than two months, to shift everything," Fabian Scheuermann, Chief Games Officer, Esports Foundation, reveals.

"It is a historic first and an honour for us. Thank you to Saudi Arabia for their trust. We are ready to host the Esports World Cup 2026. Very proud to welcome the world once again," French Prime Minister Emmanuel Macron said in May.

Preparations then moved at breakneck speed.

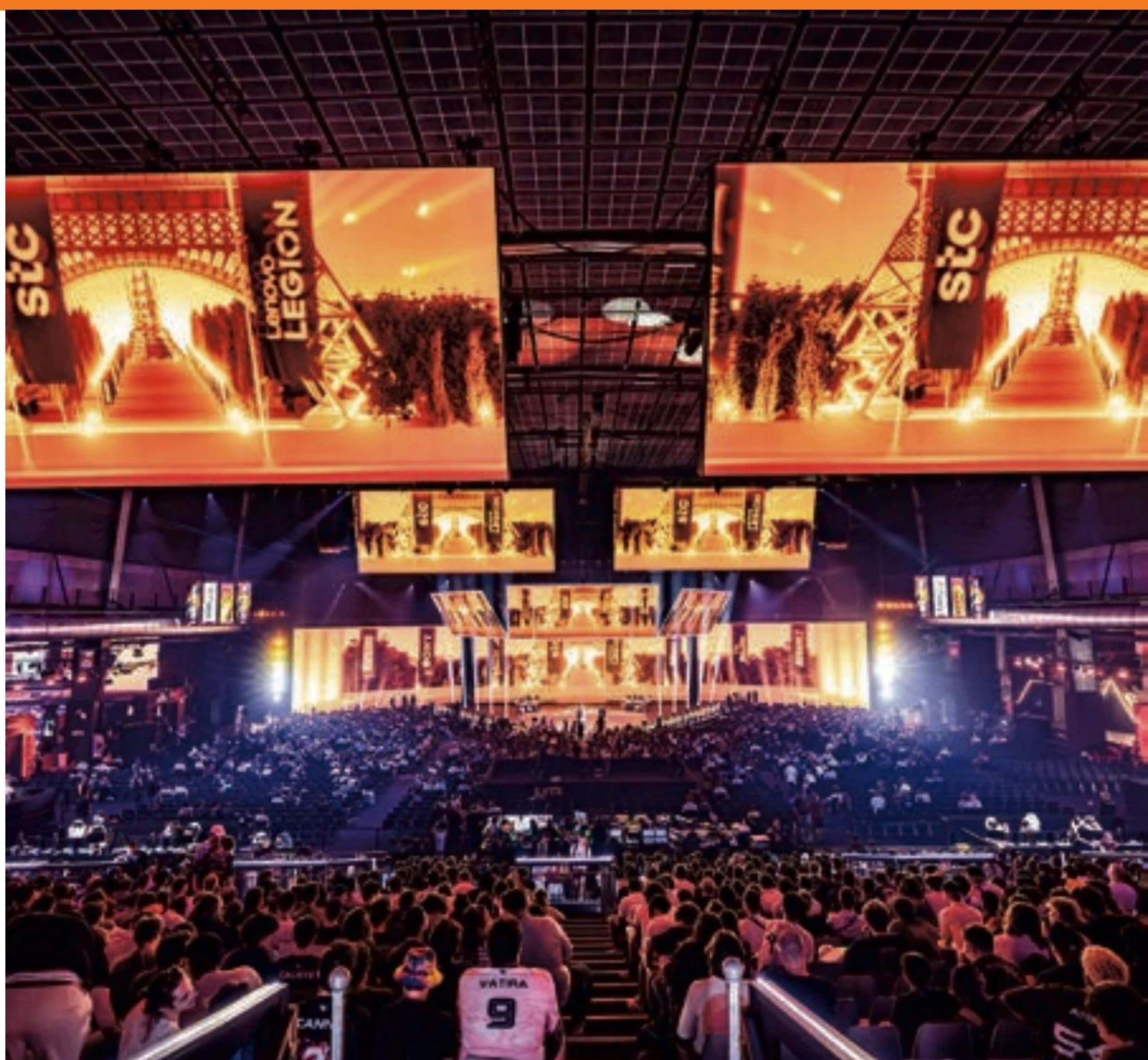
"The first question was the players. We needed to make sure that all players were safe and could compete at this level, that too, face-to-face. Secondly, we needed a place to play, which we got with the support of the French government," Scheuermann adds.

"The partnership helped a lot to make sure that we could move it to France in such a short time, which otherwise would have been impossible, to be fair. Last but not least, the hotels.

"We needed to ensure we had the hotels booked as well, as we would have done in Riyadh. Then came the fan experience, where we planned to put everything under one roof.

"Honestly, I was a little scared, but it turned out great to have the different reactions together. I felt it was a bug, but it turned out to be a feature."

By August 17, the Esports World Cup had drawn more than 11.3 million viewers, with an average audience of 3.8 million, according to



Collective roar: Scenes from the main venue of the Esports World Cup, where applause and collective sighs rang out in front of giant screen.

ESPORTS WORLD CUP MEDIA/ESPORTS FOUNDATION

